

Decision for War

In early 1965, elected president in his own right, and with authority to escalate the war as he saw fit, President Johnson committed US forces to combat in Southeast Asia in the hope of preserving an independent, noncommunist South Vietnam.

◀ BEFORE

When he became president, Johnson inherited a volatile situation in South Vietnam.

WINNING A MANDATE

Johnson ran for the presidency in 1964 as a peace candidate. A landslide victory provided him with a mandate to chart his own course, and the **Tonkin Gulf Resolution** provided congressional authorization to commit US forces to war against the North Vietnamese Army and Viet Cong guerrillas, who were attacking throughout the South.



VIET CONG BADGE

President Johnson's decision to scale up American military involvement coalesced over time. Plans for massive troop increases were laid in the early 1960s, as the United States invested heavily in military and logistical infrastructure for South Vietnam.

When economic aid, diplomatic measures, and military advising failed to quell support for the insurgency, Johnson took a more aggressive, military approach. First, though, he needed to gain public support to escalate a conflict he had promised the American people he would not ask their sons to fight.

A convenient pretext

On February 7, 1965, a Viet Cong attack on Camp Holloway, a US base near the city of Pleiku, in the Central Highlands, gave Johnson a valid pretext for just such an escalation. With eight Americans killed, dozens more wounded, and several helicopters destroyed, the Johnson administration used the attack to garner public support for deeper involvement. In response, on the same day President Johnson authorized Operation Flaming Dart, a